

The Claremont City Council held a meeting on Monday, March 16, 2020, in the Council Chambers of City Hall.

The meeting was called to order by Mayor Lovett at 5:30 p.m.

Members of the Council present were:

Ward I Councilor Andrew O’Hearne
At-Large Councilor Abigail Kier (called in late)
At-Large Councilor Erica Sweetser
Assistant Mayor Allen Damren
Mayor Charlene Lovett
At-Large Councilor Debora Matteau
At-Large Councilor Nicholas Koloski
Ward II Councilor James Contois

Absent:

Ward III Councilor Jonathan Stone

Also present:

Edward Morris, City Manager

CITIZEN’S FORUM

No one spoke.

NEW BUSINESS

Council agreed to move Other Pertinent COVID-19 Discussion to the beginning of the meeting.

Other Pertinent COVID-19 Discussion

Mr. Morris said using ICS (Incident Command System), he has set up an operations plan. The Planning and Development Department is in charge of press releases. Finance is working on the finance end of operations. There will probably be some sort of reimbursement from FEMA. Logistical – Parks and Recreation Director Mark Brislin is in charge of sanitation. Mr. Morris said he will close the City Clerk’s office tomorrow to the public; there will be a drop box outside their office for payments. Payments can also be made online.

Mr. Morris said for now he’s keeping City Hall open, and everyone is taking precautions. Offices are being staffed in order to take phone calls. Fire and Police will respond to emergencies. They have some reduced services such as not going out on nonessential calls. For other noncriminal activity, they will gather information over the phone. EMS calls for Police

have been suspended, except for high threats. For Assessing, all walk throughs have been cancelled, for now. Because this is an emergency situation, Interim Assessor Stephan Hamilton has said the April 15 deadline for abatements, tax credits, etc., will be extended. We are working to keep City workers safe as well as citizens.

At 5:35 p.m., Ms. Kier joined the Council meeting by phone.

Mr. Morris said for Public Works, critical staff is coming in and employees are staying separated. He's looking at Department Heads to figure out how to minimize staff. Regarding water and sewer bills, he's planning to extend the due dates. These will be taken on a case-by-case basis. Also, tax bills are coming up. The City will work on those in order to not make an undue hardship on citizens.

Fire Chief Bryan Burr said the Fire Department's response to calls will be slightly modified. They have protocols in place for PPE (personal protective equipment), which will limit exposure. They do this regularly. They will ask more questions of patients for medical emergencies. They will suspend all non-required interactions. For example, they won't go to public service activities.

Mr. Morris read from a press release from Governor Sununu stating the no more than 50 people can gather together at one time and that restaurants can offer off-site eating only.

Mr. Morris said regarding motor vehicle registrations, the Governor's office announced that if they are not done on time, there won't be a penalty. Even though the City Clerk's office will be closed to the public, staff will be working; he may downsize the office. He will look into how people can register new vehicles as they require a face-to-face transaction.

Regarding boards and commissions, Mr. Morris said all nonessential meetings will be cancelled. For the April 6th Zoning Board of Adjustment meeting, the applicant was happy to hear that it will be postponed.

Mr. Morris said the City can put out some information on the website to direct people to other official sites. The public can always call 2-1-1 for information. We will use the City Clerk's office for information.

Mr. Morris will update the Council, staff and citizens on a daily basis.

Mr. Morris said on an operational level, we are moving toward having people call in instead of having face-to-face meetings.

Regarding the current level of PPE, Chief Burr said none of us have enough. The State is working to get more into their cache and the City is working with the State on this.

Mr. Morris will contact the bus service to see what their plans are. The government is asking citizens to stay home as much as possible, and to not use public transportation as much as possible.

Determination of City Council Protocols during COVID-19 Outbreak

Mayor Lovett said today NHMA put out guidance that was sent to the Council. The last sentence of the preamble states that, “Nevertheless, municipal boards must meet to ensure government keeps functioning.” She said the Governor sent out a memo regarding compliance with NH’s Right-to-Know law. Normally, Councils, boards, commissions, and committees have to have a physical quorum present during a meeting, however, with the issuance of Executive Order 2020-04, all members can call in; a physical quorum is not required. As long as a physical quorum is not present, the minutes should state that this is an emergency because of COVID-19. Wherever the meeting is, there has to be a physical space for members of the public to be able to come in. The City Manager is working on getting a phone line for the public to call in.

Mr. Morris hopes to limit these meetings to essential business only. He is looking into video chat capabilities.

Mayor Lovett said all votes will be taken by roll call.

After discussion, Mayor Lovett summed up that what she heard from the Council is that the Council will meet for essential business only. Essential business is defined as critical to continued operations of the administration. Councilors agreed.

Councilors agreed to postpone indefinitely the Council Retreat.

Mayor Lovett said there are some essential items on the March 25th agenda; that meeting will convene electronically.

Mayor Lovett asked that every Councilor coordinate with the City Manager and herself about whether or not they would be in the meeting physically or electronically. Council needs to abide by the President’s 10 people limit.

Mayor Lovett said it is up to the chair of the subcommittees of the Council to determine whether or not they will hold their meetings.

Mr. Morris suggested Council should decide to cancel all meetings except for essential meetings. There are City staff working with these boards and together they can determine if a meeting is essential.

A motion was made by Mr. Koloski and seconded by Mr. Damren to cancel all board and commission meetings that are non-essential and that the Administration will work with the chair of the respective boards, commissions and committees to schedule and run the essential meetings.

Mr. Morris is working to cancel nonessential land use board meetings, however, there will be a special meeting on March 31 that is essential to be held.

Roll call vote:
O’Hearne - yes
Kier - yes
Sweetser - yes
Damren - yes
Matteau - yes
Koloski - yes
Contois - yes
Lovett - yes
Motion carried 8-0.

Mr. Morris said the City’s three electronic sign boards will be positioned throughout the City with where to look for information.

City Council Interface with Interagency Governmental Updates on COVID-19

Mayor Lovett said these calls are for state and local officials. She intends to participate and will forward information to the Council.

Ms. Sweetser thanked Mr. Morris and Chief Burr for all their work on this.

Mr. Morris thanked all the Directors; this is an unprecedented situation, and they’ve been doing a lot of hard work. He said the pre-planning started last week. Departments will keep functioning. There are no plans to put out a press release, yet. The City is working together with the SAU and the County.

Mr. Koloski invited everyone to sign up for Code Red; it’s on the Police Department webpage.

CONSULTATION WITH LEGAL COUNSEL

None

ADJOURNMENT

At 6:17 p.m., a motion was made by Ms. Kier and seconded by Mr. O’Hearne to adjourn.

Roll call vote: motion carried 8-0.

Respectfully Submitted,

Dorée M. Russell
Clerk to the Council